

Week 5: Video Transcript

Hi, I'm Sarah, and I am so glad you're here. In this session, I am going to talk to you about the science of staying calm, which is something that honestly all of us need, whether we are working with children or just any other human in our life.

And for starters, I need you to know, as you are probably already keenly aware, being calm is a job that happens from the inside out. Some people have the mindset that if everything is calmer out there, then I will be calmer in here. But in reality, things are going to continue to be kind of wild and messy out there sometimes. So the very most helpful thing we can do is create a sense of safety from deep within our very own nervous system, so that no matter what life or a child or another human being may throw at us, we have the emotional wherewithal to say, "I am operating from a place of peace and connection with my own body." So for starters, I want you to know that if you are not always perfectly calm, welcome to being human. Right? Humans are not supposed to be all calm all the time. That would be unrealistic. It would be an unfair expectation. And frankly, we are designed to get angry sometimes, right?

Being angry is one of the six core human emotions that every single person on the planet experiences from time to time. The question is, what do we do with that anger? And we have separate modules where we will get into anger more specifically. But when we want to figure out, "am I wrong for getting mad sometimes?", "Should I not have these triggers?" I want you to know that it's perfectly natural. It's human nature to have triggers, to be bothered, to be not calm sometimes. Frankly, if I'm walking down a dark alley one night and all of a sudden I am approached by an unsafe person, I'm not supposed to say, "Oh, great. It's so lovely to meet you. Here, would you like my wallet?" That's not the intent at all. I am supposed to have a big reaction sometimes, and I certainly hope I would in that moment. So our nervous system, when we are feeling the opposite of peaceful, whatever that is for us, it's because there is a time and a place for those big feelings that we carry. We're not wrong to have them. We're not wrong to express them. The question is, are we expressing ourselves through the lens of non-violent communication? Which, once again, we discuss elsewhere in this program as well. But for starters, the biggest takeaway I want you to have is to know that you make sense, your triggers make sense. You are not wrong for feeling dysregulated sometimes. It's part of the human experience.



In fact, our nervous system has two major states from which we operate all of the time. One is called the parasympathetic state, where this is known as rest and digest. This is where I can exhale. I can literally rest. I can literally digest my food, digest life as it is given to me. This is the place where I feel peaceful most of the time. Likewise, the other side is the sympathetic nervous system. This is the part of my nervous system from which I activate, from which I take action and movement and am called to engage.

The question is, am I engaging peacefully or am I engaging in a way that is showing my inner dysregulation? Again, there are times to be dysregulated, and that can be the healthiest thing you do in certain scenarios. But from this place of dysregulation, can we find ways to activate, to meet that legitimate nervous system state, but activate in a way that will do no harm to ourselves or to those around us? Now, very briefly, as we explore what that looks like, I need you to know that we are talking about something called polyvagal theory, and we also get deeper into the discussion of that in the program. However, I want you to know that our nervous system is operating from three sub-states, if you will, when we are in that activation mode.

One is sometimes I am in what is called my ventral state. By the way, there is no quiz on the big fancy terms, but my ventral state is where I feel empowered. It's where I feel playful. It's where I feel creative. It's where I feel socially engaged in the conversations that I have with the people around me. This is a great place to be. But honestly, it's not healthy or even normal or possible to be there all the time. You can imagine this part of your nervous system as essentially being your inner cheerleader saying, "You've got this. This is going to be amazing. How exciting." But honestly, if we walked around like that all the time, it would be pretty annoying, not only to us, but also to those around us. We don't need our inner cheerleader to be driving the boat all the time. Sometimes we need to be in a more relaxed state.

The middle state, if you will, is what I'm going to call fight or flight. Now, this does not necessarily mean that it's a bad thing. Fight doesn't mean a literal fistfight. Fight can mean I am moving forward. I am getting stuff done. I am moving in a way where I can achieve things. I might not feel super empowered and super creative and like my optimal cheerleader self, but I am active in this state. Likewise, if there is conflict, perhaps I am in more of a fight state, but it is coming from a deep desire within my body to actually create relational safety. Because when I am in fight mode and it is not peaceful, it is my body's work to get me safe in whatever ways it knows how. So if I am being less than peaceful, I

have opportunities which I will share momentarily to do some very specific things to create a greater sense of safety within my body so that I can still get stuff done, so that I can still have my boundaries, so that I can still communicate effectively and clearly with those around me, but coming from a place of peacefulness inside rather than a place of reactivity. The other part of that fight or flight is the flight part. Sometimes that looks like, you know what, I need to take a break. But it is a conscious, peaceful decision to say, "I'm taking a break right now, and I need to be out of here." Of course, there's also a more intense version of this, which is, "Woo, I'm out. I am out quickly." If I were in that same dark alley, sometimes my very best option is to run. But when we are talking about a child in front of me, I don't actually need to run. The child is very likely not an actual threat to my well-being, but my nervous system might still perceive the child as a threat, therefore I might be more likely to want to check out emotionally. Again, we are not wrong for feeling these things. These are evolutionary adaptations that have helped keep humans alive and well since the beginning of humanity. But once again, we have some evidence-based ways to get curious about, am I fleeing, am I retreating in a healthy way, or perhaps am I excessively retreating to the point of creating emotional disconnection, which, of course, is the opposite of what I want. And within the context of the science of staying calm, our biggest job right now is to get curious about where am I spending most of my time, and am I handling those nervous system states in ways that are going to be conducive to creating a more relationally secure relationship with the people around me.

The third state, if you will, is the dorsal state of the nervous system. There is literally a medical term called the dorsal dive, which is really the fancy way to say fainting. That is when the body says, "I am out immediately. I'm down." But from a nervous system relational perspective, we don't always need to be that extreme. Sometimes it just means when I am in that dorsal state, I need to check out. I just need to totally check out. The emotional equivalent that we might hear ourselves say is, "I can't even, I can't deal. This is something that I cannot be involved in, so I'm going to go sit down, or I'm going to go take a nap" or whatever it might be, because we just cannot continue to engage in a relationally healthy, active way. Now, I don't know about you, but I need sleep sometimes. That is a form of shutting down. Shutting down isn't bad. In fact, none of these states is inherently problematic. Every single one of them is designed within the body to be supportive of your nervous system, supportive of your relationships.

So my question to you is, where do you tend to spend most of your time? Are you the chronic cheerleader? Are you the chronic napper or person who needs to check out? Or are you so busy doing that you have a hard time being? So as you get curious about where you



spend most of your time, I ask you how you can lean into some of those other states so that they too become a part of the balance that you deserve to experience in your life.

So with that, I promised you some evidence-based tools to help operate from a place of greater safety within your body so that you can have greater relational safety as well. So these tools are certainly not all inclusive. There are others that can be wildly supportive as well. But everything that I share here and in this program is deeply evidence-based, and I want you to know that research exists for all of it, and that is all that I will share here, knowing, once again, that there are other tools available that I'm not listing here, primarily because there are things that we cannot possibly cover in a short video. But with no further ado, I will share some of those now.

One of those, and these are in no particular order, one of these is EFT tapping. And I won't go into the details of how these things work here in this short video, but I encourage you to look up EFT tapping because it is evidence-based.

Another one is let's check in with your breath. If you are in a chronic state of hypervigilance, as many of us are, if we are struggling to stay peaceful, we are likely doing very shallow breaths. We are essentially hyperventilating in that really chronic fight or flight state where we don't feel completely safe in our body. So if breathwork feels accessible to you, and it doesn't to everybody, just check in and see if your exhale is longer than your inhale. It's simple. Some people like box breathing or counting on their fingers while they breathe. There are lots of ways to do effective breathwork, but the easiest thing that I can encourage you to do is simply check to see if your exhale is longer than your inhale because that creates a signal to your brain that this is not actually an emergency. I can choose to be peaceful in this moment.

Likewise, I encourage you to do either progressive muscle relaxation where you visualize just relaxing every single muscle in your body. Along with that, stretching is evidence-based because when you stretch your body, you release what I will informally call the happy chemicals in your body. Because again, this signals safety to the brain. So go ahead, play along at home if you want to. Go ahead and stretch, notice where you're holding your tension, and simply soften those parts of your body while you stretch.

I invite you, if this feels accessible to you, into meditation. Meditation, words of affirmation are incredibly powerful. Prayer is evidence-based. If you pray, pause to pray. Make it part of your daily practice. That can create greater safety in your body.

Likewise, large muscle movements can do wonderful things for creating safety. Some of us simply need to push our hands together as hard as we can or pull our palms apart as hard as we can. Push against a kitchen counter, something that is immobile. Whatever it is, engaging the large muscle groups can be wildly comforting to the nervous system.

Skin-to-skin contact, you can do it with yourself, even if it's not always skin to skin because clothing, right? But hugs are wildly regulating when they are consent-based and safe.

Certainly time in nature. Go outside. Do all these things outside if you possibly can. In fact, take this video outside if you want to. Say a prayer outside, do a meditation, do your stretching, do whatever feels right to your body. But an outdoor setting can be wildly comforting to a hypervigilant nervous system. Studies say that when you go outside, your blood pressure immediately drops in measurable levels. That's profound, isn't it?

I hope all of these tips have been helpful and supportive to you. I promise you there is more, and we will work through more of them in the program itself. But my biggest invitation to you as you walk away from this video right now is to check in with your body, notice what you are feeling, get curious about what you are needing that you can provide to yourself. Maybe it's a glass of water.

By the way, that's another one I'll just throw in for bonus points. Drinking water, particularly cold water for some people, can activate the vagus nerve that also sends signals of safety to the body. For some people, it's splashing cold water on their face or washing their hands in cold water. All of these things are evidence-based as well.

But know your body. For me, I'm not a cold water person. It actually creates stress in my body. I'm a warm tea kind of girl. So if you're a warm tea person or something else that just creates safety for you, you know your body best. I invite you to practice these things regularly when you're feeling emotionally regulated so that you create the mental muscle memory to practice them in the moments where you do feel less peaceful than usual. I hope this has been helpful. I would love to hear your comments and feedback.

I wish you a wonderful, peaceful day, and thank you so much for being here.